



Small Shifts, *Real Results*

Eight practical changes to how higher ed does business, from admissions to alumni, and the outcomes they unlock.

DéRecco Lynch, Ed.D · Brian Harris

PUBLISHED BY THE EXCELLENCE FACTORY

derecco.com

SOURCES

Selingo, J. (2026, July 2). The business model of colleges is broken. It's about to get worse. *TIME*.
<https://time.com/article/2026/07/02/the-business-model-of-colleges-is-broken-it-s-about-to-get-worse/>

Lynch, D., & Harris, B. (2026). *Why higher ed moves too slow (and what industry already knows)* [Conference presentation]. AACRAO 2026 Annual Meeting.

The real cost of moving slow

The demographic cliff didn't create these problems. It exposed them.

THE PROOF OF CONCEPT

The Bearcats Playbook, the operating system we actually ran.

[Open the playbook →](#)

THE WHY NOW

TIME on why higher ed's business model is breaking.

[Read the article →](#)

In July 2026, *TIME* made the case that higher ed's business model is breaking, and the pressure is only building: the enrollment cliff, federal funding cuts, and new caps on student loans. The diagnosis is right, and most of it is outside your control.

What you *can* control is how your institution responds. That is what this playbook is for. It won't fix your business model. It will help you stop losing the ground you never had to lose:

A market you could have won

A territory, transfer partnership, or adult-learner segment another institution captured while you were still in committee.

A person you lost

A high performer who burned out waiting on clarity, decision rights, or any sign of forward movement.

A student experience you compromised

A confusing portal, a delayed message, a siloed handoff that made students feel like they were navigating five universities.

A retention fix you delayed

A process change that would have removed friction for students, pushed again to "next cycle."

Four patterns worth rethinking

None of this is about people not caring. These are four habits most of us stopped noticing. A small change to each one changes how the whole institution feels.

THE PATTERN	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	WHAT IT COSTS
Over-consensus culture	Every decision needs broad agreement. Conversations keep expanding instead of closing.	<i>Delayed action. Diluted accountability. Stalled momentum.</i>
Undefined decision rights	No clear decider. Meetings end without ownership. Work gets revisited again and again.	<i>Confusion. Duplication. Frustrated teams.</i>
Planning confused with progress	Long strategy cycles. Detailed decks. Reframing instead of executing.	<i>The illusion of movement. No measurable outcome.</i>
Risk avoidance over results	Waiting for certainty. Choosing the safe option. Avoiding bold experiments.	<i>Missed opportunities. Incremental change in a fast market.</i>

The same reflex sits under all four: when something is hard, we add a meeting, a committee, or another round of input — and call the delay "being thorough."

A 2-minute self-check

Score each statement from 1 to 5. Be honest. This only works if it's true.

1 = rarely true 5 = happens all the time

We require broad agreement before most decisions move forward.

In our meetings, it's not always clear who makes the final call.

We spend more time planning initiatives than executing and testing them.

We default to "let's wait" instead of piloting small, fast experiments.

YOUR TOTAL

4–8

Clear and decisive.

9–15

Real friction to fix.

16–20

Something structural is in the way.

What industry already knows

None of this is new. It's what fast-moving organizations outside higher ed have run on for years, the truths higher ed tends to resist.

Small teams beat big committees

Clear ownership beats shared ambiguity

Sprints beat long planning cycles

Enablement is ongoing, not a one-time onboarding

So the enrollment division I led at the University of Cincinnati stopped leaving how we operate to chance and started treating it as a system we could design. Not a reorg. A new set of defaults.

What follows are the eight moves we ran, and exactly how to start each one on your own team this month.

THE 8 MOVES

Each move pairs what we actually did with the smallest first step you can take now.

01 Build startup teams

WHAT WE DID

- Small, cross-functional pilot teams
- Clear problem statements
- Fast test, fast learn — scale or kill

DO THIS NOW

- Pick one problem you've been over-planning
 - Pull 3–5 people
 - Give them 30 days and real decision authority
-

02 Give employee success an owner

WHAT WE DID

- One role focused on alignment, flow, and follow-through
- Fewer silos across eight teams
- Less duplication; more clarity, performance, and culture

DO THIS NOW

- If you can't hire a chief of staff, name a temporary integrator
- Their job: unblock leaders, track priorities, enforce decisions

03 Clear decision rights

WHAT WE DID

- Killed "we need more voices" and "let's revisit next meeting"
- Replaced them with who decides, who advises, who executes

DO THIS NOW

- Pick one recurring decision
- Name the decider, the advisors, the owners — out loud, in writing

04 Run decision sprints

WHAT WE DID

- Replaced months of planning with focused execution windows
- Adopted a clear point-of-view model for each sprint

DO THIS NOW

- Try a 14–30 day sprint
- One goal. One owner.
- Weekly check-ins that move work, not status theater

05 Fewer, better meetings

WHAT WE DID

- Meetings tied to outcomes; more deciding, less reporting
- Written updates over live ones
- A meeting audit every 90 days

DO THIS NOW

- Audit your calendar
- Kill or shorten one standing meeting this month
- Replace it with an async update

06 Operate on priorities, not noise

WHAT WE DID

- Clear annual priorities
- Every team maps its work back to them
- If it doesn't align, it doesn't get airtime

DO THIS NOW

- Name your top three priorities
- Ask every team to tie their projects to one of them

07 Year-round enablement

WHAT WE DID

- Enablement beyond onboarding
- Skills, leadership, and clarity treated as ongoing work
- Playbooks instead of tribal knowledge

DO THIS NOW

- Find one process people constantly ask about
- Document it
- Make it visible to everyone

08 Build partnership platforms

WHAT WE DID

- Leveraged community partners, corporate partners, and athletics
- Storytelling at scale

DO THIS NOW

- Name one non-traditional partner
- Ask how they can help tell your story, not just sponsor it

One year. Same people. Different defaults.

Proof of concept: team survey results from the enrollment division I led at the University of Cincinnati, running what we called the Bearcats Playbook, 2024 to 2025.

Belonging 40%

90%

Sense of belonging

+50 points

Leadership 30%

85%

Confidence in leadership

+55 points

Role clarity 58%

81%

Clarity of role expectations

+23 points

Collaboration across teams

54% → 67% +13

Clarity of performance management

50% → 70% +20

*We never ran a belonging campaign.
We stopped making people wait.*

Design your first small shift

Don't adopt all eight moves at once. Pick one. Run it for 30 days.

01

Where does one process create the most friction for students or staff?

Be specific: a workflow, a recurring decision, a policy, a handoff.

02

Which of the eight moves would help most there?

Startup team? Decision rights? A sprint? A meeting audit?

03

What would a 30-day experiment look like?

Clear outcome. One owner. Defined timeline.

04

What's one risk you're willing to tolerate to make the change?

What we learned

Don't make the same mistakes we did. Use our growing pains to move with intention.

01 Stay human.

Balance transformation with continuity. Speed is a tool, not the mission.

02 Align every move with your mission.

If a change doesn't move the needle for the people you serve, question it.

03 Build feedback in from day one.

Decide up front how you'll know it's working, and how you'll respond when the context shifts.

04 Keep it about the work.

Don't let personalities or politics stall progress. Cut through the noise and center the work.

05 Start with the outcome.

Know what will be true because you acted — then work backward to the first move.

Work through your own version with AI

I shaped this playbook with an AI thinking partner. It didn't hand me the framework or the results. My team did. What it did was make me faster and sharper. Here are the prompts I'd give you to design your own version, plus three rules that make them work.

Bring the point of view.

Give it your real context. No point of view in, no point of view out.

Truth is non-negotiable.

Your job is to tell it "no, that's not how it works here."

Keep the judgment.

AI drafts. You decide what's true and what ships.

PROMPT 01 · DIAGNOSE WHERE YOU GET STUCK

"Act as a candid operations advisor for a higher-ed team. Here's how a recent decision actually went: **[3 to 4 sentences]**. Using these four patterns (over-consensus, undefined decision rights, planning mistaken for progress, risk avoidance), tell me which one is holding us back most, and the evidence for it. Don't flatter me."

PROMPT 02 · PICK THE HIGHEST-LEVERAGE MOVE

"My team is slowest here: **[the pattern or bottleneck]**. From these eight moves (startup teams, an integrator role, clear decision rights, decision sprints, fewer and better meetings, priorities over noise, year-round enablement, partnership platforms), which two would unlock the most speed in the next 90 days, and what would we have to give up to run them?"

PROMPT 03 · DESIGN A 30-DAY EXPERIMENT

"Help me design one 30-day experiment to move faster on **[specific process or decision]**. Give me a single clear outcome, one owner, a weekly check-in cadence, the smallest version worth testing, and how we'll know it worked. Keep it to one page."

THE BONUS · PROMPTS, CONTINUED

PROMPT 04 · CLARIFY DECISION RIGHTS

"We keep revisiting this decision: [name it]. Help me set clear decision rights. Draft a simple map of who decides, who advises, and who executes, plus the three questions I need to answer to end the ambiguity for good."

PROMPT 05 · AUDIT YOUR MEETINGS

"Here are my team's standing meetings and their stated purpose: [list them]. For each, tell me whether to keep, shorten, merge, make async, or kill it, and what outcome it would need to justify staying on the calendar. Flag the ones that produce reports instead of decisions."

PROMPT 06 · RED-TEAM IT BEFORE YOU COMMIT

"Here's my plan to move faster: [paste it]. Argue against it. Where will this break inside a real institution? What am I underestimating about politics, capacity, or change fatigue? Give me the three most likely failure points and how to de-risk each. Don't spare my feelings."

PROMPT 07 · TURN IT INTO A CABINET BRIEF

"Turn the plan below into a one-page brief for a president or cabinet: the problem, the move, the 30-day experiment, the metric, and the ask. Executive tone, no jargon. [paste your plan]"

The tools are getting extraordinary. The judgment about how to use them is the invisible economy of the next decade. Bring yours.



HIGHER ED DOESN'T NEED

More committees

More planning decks

More meetings

Clarity

Courage

Focus

Merit gets you in the room.
How your team **decides** is what wins once you're there.

Higher-ed leadership tools, the podcast, and the next playbook, all at

derecco.com

Follow DéRecco Lynch, Ed.D, on LinkedIn for the ideas behind this playbook.

Proof of concept: [the Bearcats Playbook](#) · The TIME piece: [read it here](#)

Adapts the framework DéRecco Lynch, Ed.D, and Brian Harris presented at AACRAO 2026. The results are the proof of concept: the Bearcats Playbook, run in the enrollment division led by Lynch at the University of Cincinnati, 2024–2025.
Reference: Selingo, J. (2026, July 2). *The business model of colleges is broken. It's about to get worse.* TIME.



THE INVISIBLE LETTER · FREE EVERY SUNDAY

See the 70% everyone else **misses**.

In higher ed, most of what decides outcomes is invisible. Not the org chart or the strategic plan. The relationships, the engagement, and the timing that quietly determine who advances, which ideas move, and what students actually experience. Every Sunday, The Invisible Letter breaks it down in five minutes.

30%

The visible: the org chart, the strategic plan, the policies, the committee minutes.

70%

The invisible: who actually decides, whose voice carries, how work really moves, and what students feel but never say.

Field notes on the invisible economy, from the person behind it. Subscribe free and unlock The Framework Vault and The Invisible Score the moment you join.

Subscribe free at derecco.com

Join 500+ readers. One email a week. No fluff. Unsubscribe anytime.